FREE SAMPLE

The Shadow Work Academy

Module 1: Meet Your Shadow

This is the complete first module of the six-module academy, exactly as customers receive it.

MODULE 1 OF 6

Meet Your Shadow

Learn to read your own patterns before you try to change them.

Lesson

What “shadow work” actually means here

“Shadow” is a term popularized by the psychiatrist Carl Jung. In everyday use it describes the parts of ourselves we have learned to hide, push down, or not look at: needs we were told were too much, feelings that felt unwelcome, qualities we judged in ourselves or in other people.

In this academy we use the word in a practical, grounded way. Shadow work simply means getting curious about the patterns you run on autopilot: the reactions that surprise you, the situations that keep repeating, the moments where you act against what you know is good for you. You are not digging for hidden monsters. You are learning to notice what is already there, name it accurately, and decide what to do with it.

This is self-reflection, not therapy. It cannot diagnose anything or replace care from a qualified professional, and you should feel free to stop, slow down, or seek support at any point.

Why patterns matter more than single moments

One awkward conversation tells you very little. The same awkward conversation happening for the fourth time with different people tells you a lot. Patterns are where self-understanding becomes useful, because a pattern points to a need, a belief, or a habit that is doing quiet work in the background.

A pattern usually has four parts, and learning to separate them is the single most useful skill in this module:

- Trigger — the situation or signal that sets things off (a delayed reply, a raised tone, being asked for a favor).
- Automatic reaction — what you feel and do before you have time to decide (your stomach drops, you apologize, you say yes).
- Story — the meaning you attach, often instantly (“I’ve upset them,” “I’m failing,” “they don’t respect me”).

- Payoff and cost — what the reaction protects you from in the short term, and what it costs you over time.

Every pattern had a reason

Most automatic reactions began as sensible solutions. A child who learned that keeping the peace kept the house calm becomes an adult who agrees too quickly. A student who was only praised for results becomes someone who cannot rest without producing. The reaction worked once, so it got repeated until it stopped feeling like a choice.

This matters because it changes the tone of the work. If a pattern once helped you, then judging yourself for it is inaccurate as well as unkind. The more useful question is: “What is this pattern trying to protect, and is it still the best way to do that?”

How to tell a trigger from a cause

A trigger is not the same as the reason you react. Your coworker’s short email is the trigger; the reason it hurts may be an older belief that you are only valued when you are useful. Triggers are easy to spot because they are external. Causes take a little patience, because they sit underneath.

A reliable clue is proportion. When your reaction is noticeably larger or longer-lasting than the event seems to warrant, something beneath the surface has been touched. That is not evidence that you are overreacting in a bad way. It is a signpost telling you where to look.

How to do this work safely

Work at a pace that leaves you steady. If a prompt stirs up something heavy, you are allowed to skip it, shorten your answer, or come back another day. Choose a time and place where you will not be interrupted, and finish each session with something grounding: a glass of water, a short walk, a message to a friend.

If you are experiencing persistent distress, thoughts of harming yourself, or you are dealing with trauma or abuse, please contact a licensed mental health professional or local emergency services. This program is a self-guided educational tool and is not a substitute for professional care.

Scenario: The unanswered message

Maya sends a long, careful message to a friend about weekend plans. Three hours pass with no reply. By the evening she has re-read her message several times, decided she sounded needy, and drafted two apologies she has not sent. Her stomach feels tight and she cannot concentrate on dinner.

Here is Maya's pattern, separated into parts. Trigger: silence after sending a message. Automatic reaction: tight stomach, re-reading, drafting apologies. Story: "I said too much and now they're annoyed with me." Payoff: preparing an apology feels like control over a situation she cannot control. Cost: an evening of anxiety and a habit of over-apologizing for things that did not need an apology.

Notice that Maya did nothing wrong. The pattern is not her flaw; it is a learned way of managing uncertainty. Once she can see the four parts, she has a gap between the trigger and her reaction, and a gap is where choice lives.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. Think of a recent moment when your reaction felt bigger than the situation. What happened, and what did you feel in your body first?

2. What story did your mind attach to that moment? Write it in the exact words it used, even if the words feel harsh.

3. Where have you seen a very similar reaction before — a different person or place, but the same feeling?

4. If this reaction once helped you, what was it protecting you from? Who or what taught you it was necessary?

5. What does this pattern cost you now, in energy, relationships, or choices?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Pattern Map

Choose three recent situations that left you tense, defensive, or drained. Fill in one row for each. Aim for specific facts, not summaries. “My boss changed the deadline in a meeting” is better than “work stress.”

Completed example (fictional): Maya's Pattern Map

TRIGGER

A friend hadn't replied to a long message after three hours.

AUTOMATIC REACTION

Tight stomach. Re-read my message four times. Drafted two apologies I didn't send.

STORY I TOLD MYSELF

"I said too much and now they're annoyed with me."

WHAT IT PROTECTED / WHAT IT COST

Protected: preparing an apology felt like control. Cost: an anxious evening and a habit of over-apologizing.

WHAT THE ROWS HAVE IN COMMON

When I can't tell what someone thinks of me, I try to fix it before I know there is a problem.

NAME FOR THE PATTERN

"The Apology Draft"

Fictional example for illustration. Your own answers can be shorter, messier, and entirely different.

Trigger (what happened)	Automatic reaction (feeling + action)	Story I told myself	What it protected / what it cost

Looking across your three rows, what do they have in common?

Give this pattern a short, neutral name (for example “The Apology Draft” or “Quiet Scorekeeping”).

Real-world action: The three-second notice

For the next seven days, catch one automatic reaction per day. You are not trying to stop it. At the moment it happens, silently name the trigger and the story (“Trigger: silence. Story: I annoyed them.”). Afterwards, jot it into the Trigger & Pattern Tracker in your resource library. The goal is observation only.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- Shadow work here means getting curious about your automatic patterns, not hunting for something wrong with you.
- A pattern has four parts: trigger, automatic reaction, story, and payoff/cost.
- Most patterns began as reasonable solutions, so self-judgment is both inaccurate and unhelpful.
- A reaction that feels bigger than the event is a signpost pointing to something underneath.
- Go at a steady pace and seek professional support when you need it.

The Shadow Work Academy is an educational self-reflection program and is not therapy, diagnosis, or medical advice. Personal use only; please do not share or resell.